Humayun ordered half to be returned. The remaining gems and coins he distributed amongst his ‘servants and followers’ – the clothes he kept for himself.[47]

Thus, dressed in what finery he could muster and able to acknowledge Rana Prasad’s hospitality with gifts of sword belts and armour, Humayun embarked on what he and his followers must have hoped would be a new and more fortunate chapter of his life. In this, they would be quite wrong; but that does not deprive Umarkot of significance in Mughal chronicles. It was here, after all, in Umarkot, where you could buy four goats for one rupee,[48] and mango trees perfumed the air; it was here, as the summer waned and the refugees began to recover their strength, that the very first words of another and more glorious life were written.

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By Abul Fazl’s account,[49] the seven weeks between 22 August and 15 October, the last two months of Hamida’s pregnancy, were crowded with good omens. One day, for example, Hamida was riding in her litter through one of Umarkot’s famous mango orchards, its trees as heavy with fruit as she was. A sudden craving overtook her, and she sent her brother, Muazzam, to bring her an armful of mangoes. When the boy returned, he was half-blinded by the light reflecting off her brow, and asked, ‘Have you put a mirror on your forehead?’

Nothing of the sort, she replied, yet Muazzam could not look her full in the face, for all the ‘glory of the divine light’ that shone from it.

Light is the predominant theme of these omens. Jiji Anaka, future wet nurse to Hamida’s child, told Abul Fazl of how a ‘great light’ settled on her bosom. ‘I felt,’ she said, ‘as if the world-warming Sun had fallen into my breast.’ Humayun was not spared such visitation either. He was having a party in a room with a latticed window, the assembly was attempting to divine the date of the ‘glorious birth’, when ‘[s]uddenly rays of divine light shone from the lattices’.

The visions piled up, the day of the birth drew close, and yet, only three days before Hamida delivered her baby, Humayun left Umarkot. It’s possible, of course, that Humayun didn’t want to go. Why would he not want to welcome the new life that Hamida and he had managed, somehow,